Tom Thomson in Purgatory

By Troy Jollimore

INTRODUCTION

Purgatory is believed by Roman Catholics, and very few other Christians, to be a location or state where the souls of most individuals go at the time of death. The purpose of purgatory is to cleanse the individual from the temporal consequences of her or his sins while on earth. Eventually, the person will be eligible to be transferred to Heaven

.

Tom Thomson has reached the end of his life . . he's not a hero, he's not famous – He is "everyman" and for this very reason we can identify with the inventory of his life.

He's Tom Tomson in Purgatory by Troy Jollimore.

Sin Cleansing # 1: Tom Thomson in his office, Thursday afternoon

Fills out grant applications. Honestly.
Although they asked him not to. That's, you know,
against the rules. Is honesty, that is.
And knows he therefore will not one red cent

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get from them this year. Nor desires he to.
Rejection is his muse. He thrives on it!
(Who else can say they thrive on anything?)
These days, that is. (His father's phrase.) But he's
more strong than they by far: For he can smile
and hoist a planet onto shoulder, he
can laugh at pain (and knows more pain than they)
more pain, more love, more lust, more everything!
He is made stronger what does not kill him.
And what does kill him, make him stronger still.

Sin Cleansing # 2: Tom Thomson in His Library

Bookplates, he useth not. Nor needs he to.
Reason the First: all his books share his scent,
a musk of salt-sea air, pine redolent,
and hint of freshly doused campfire (suggest-
ing liberty to some, but to the rest
the reek of disappointment.) Crack the spine
and sniff: you'll know if from his cache it came.
Reason the Next: he has not loaned a book

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to anyone for ten plus years. For no
one reads no more, and fewer people still
read what he reads, or feel the slightest pull
to transact business -- giftings, borrowings --
with this musty old man whose books all smell
of salt, of lonesome woods, of drenched dead flames.

Sin Cleansing # 3: Tom Thomson in Limbo

Each thing done is a thousand things not done:
to read Frost is to not-read Henry James
or Keats and/or Rimbaud or Heisenberg ...
(Calculus floors him. Physics spins his mind
beyond all equilibrium.) But worse,
to read anyone else's books is to
not-write his own. But why, when others' songs
fill all the airwaves full, should lack of song
on his own part make him feel shameful so?
If every ear already is stuffed dumb,
why want a voice? (He knows what she'd suggest:

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pure egotism.) "In silence can man best
preserve his own integrity," fortune
from fortune cookie say. "And he say " ."

Sin Cleansing # 4: Tom Thomson in Stereo

The all-day all-night FM radio station
that broadcasts just south of his cerebellum
has switched formats. Now
it's Greatest Misses From Your Teens and Twenties:
a looped guitar set on Repeat Repeat
overdub-echoed, greased with Frippertronics;
an anxious dream in which, again, again,
he do, he say, exactly the wrong thing,
or miss the meaningful, inviting glance,
or stand on shore as the last boat, last chance,
pass by his little island. Twist the knob,
the song remain the same. He needs anten-
nae longer than the ones he got to hear
the tune of glad heart that must somewhere play.

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Sin Cleansing # 5: Tom Thomson in Transit

"That train's not run here for a thousand years."
(He means a hundred, maybe?) "They still sell
the tickets at the station, though, if any-
one would like a useless souvenir ... "

And Tom is tempted: he do love useless things.
Remind him, they, of someone he knows well.
His wallet's stuffed with currency from all
manner of countries not in business now;

his camera aches for discontinued film.
(Ditto his typewriter & its odd ribbon.)
And all his maps are maps of continents
that sank without a trace some time ago,

flora and fauna gone extinct, extinct
as Tom himself feel he must surely go.

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Sin Cleansing # 6: Tom Thomson in Doubt

Lay down them projects for the crackling stars.
The hourglass sifts itself. Stars sprawl and blaze
in every each direction, and their howl
torments him into sleep. There was a point
from which they all emerged, of infinite mass,
through which he right now passes possibly through,
knowing it not. But then, what does he know?
And what could tell he to another ear?
Ears tilt away from him now when he speaks,
and people form strange patterns, fields, as if
a magnet he, and iron filings they.
"Lay down," he just repeats, "them projects." He
gives often to himself advice, and trusts
himself, though less these days, to get it right.

Cleansing Complete: Tom Thomson in Flanders Fields

The poppies grow, between the crosses row
by regimented row, and as they bob

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pathetic Tom bobs too (I mean *sym-*
pathetic, for our man is overcome

and only refuge he can find is in
corrective fantasy: 1916
with Thomson gun in one hand, Thomson girl
in other, doffs his cap he, take his leave,

and head to France to shoot up several Germans.
(Ignore the fact that he's a pacifist,
and closest he has come to shoot a gun
is his excessive use of bullet points;

it's *his* fantasy, for Christ's sake!)) Tom,
he linger for a while, then go home.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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